

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- India's T20 setup has seen a clear shift under Suryakumar and Gambhir: No focus on milestones, decisions linked to team's needs
- Abhishek's three ducks did not cost him his place. Leadership assurance reduced pressure and enabled the final knock
- Sanju rebounded from a weak New Zealand series and selection doubts, reset his mindset and peaked when it mattered
- Abhishek aims to play all formats, but has stopped chasing outcomes. Sanju just wants to savour the moment

absolutely broken," he said. But the wicketkeeper-batsman started "preparing again". After the loss to South Africa in the Super 8s, the stakes rose: India had to "win four out of four" to retain the Cup. That's when Sanju told himself that the team "needs you to step up".

His partnership with Abhishek, though, rarely looked strained. "So, we have kind of a Kerala-Punjabi friendship going in the middle," Sanju said. "We just don't complicate things...ball is coming straight, hit it." Abhishek leans on Sanju's calm support: "You feel that you have someone behind you." Sanju values Abhishek's partnership on and off the field: "He's a very brave, open-hearted kid."

Both trace their success back to home. Abhishek's father, a former cricketer, built his game and stayed by his side throughout. "It wasn't easy for him to see me going through this phase," Abhishek said. The support never wavered—"turning up for all games...trying everything, even *puja-paath* (prayers), which he had never done." Samson's father made a decisive call early on. He left his job in Delhi Police and moved to Kerala so his son could pursue cricket seriously. "This is all part of his vision," Sanju said, "and I'm very happy that it is coming true." ■

ABHISHEK SHARMA

Batsman

> **In India, the amount of love people show also brings huge expectations.... Sometimes you deliver, sometimes you don't, but that's how a cricketer's life is. I've accepted it**
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> **I am just going to follow my process, which I've been taught in the last two years by Mr Yuvraj Singh. I should not worry about things that are not in my hand**